

Communication Techniques

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Communication, which includes both giving and receiving information, doesn't come easily to everyone.

Communication is quite a complicated thing, but strong communication techniques can serve you well in all aspects of life.

When you think of communication, verbal conversation might come to mind first.

Communication goes beyond conversation, of course, but sharing ideas with others does require the ability to clearly convey what you're thinking.

Charge your words with your feelings

Your words become more sincere when you infuse them with feelings.

Shared emotions can help you connect with others more easily.

But you can't share how you're really feeling unless you're in touch with your emotions.

Speak clearly, without rushing

It is very common to speak quickly when you're nervous or feel a little unsure of yourself.

If you speak too quickly, though, listeners might find your words hard to follow.

Take a few deep breaths before you start speaking, and focus on the sound and shape of each word in your mouth.

This can help you slow down and really focus on what you're saying.

Choose your words carefully

Your choice of words and phrases, can have an impact on your overall message.

Think about how you talk to your best friend, your mother, and your boss. Do you use the same words and phrases or vary them somewhat?

It is important to be yourself, but it also helps to consider your audience when trying to communicate more effectively.

For example, swearing in front of your child's teacher or a family member might give a different impression than you want to convey.

Disagree respectfully

Different opinions do not have to ruin a friendship, relationship, or even casual conversation. You might agree with many of the people you talk to, but you might have plenty of differences, too.

When you disagree sometimes, just take care to:

- acknowledge their perspective
- share your perspective politely
- avoid contempt and judgment
- keep an open mind

Ask questions

A good conversation should go both ways.

You want to share things about yourself, but you will also want to ask insightful questions and listen to their answers for the clarification of information.

On your end, show engagement and interest by giving detailed responses when someone asks you a question.

Mind your body language

While spoken words might carry a lot of weight, your body language can also convey a lot.

When it comes to communication, *how do you say* something matters just as much as *what do you say*.

Your words and body language should go together.

Maintain eye contact

Maintaining eye contact in a conversation can show your interest in what they say.

It also conveys a sense of openness and honesty.

Looking someone in the eye suggests you don't have anything to hide.

The way to man's heart is through his eyes.

Be relaxed

Be relaxed and feel at home when you are communicating with others.

If you feel a little nervous during a conversation, your facial muscles might tense up, which could make you seem irritated or stressed.

It might feel natural to sit with your legs crossed or fold your arms across your chest when standing. But doing this in a conversation can sometimes give an impression of being closed off or disinterested in new ideas.

Avoid fidgeting

Fidgeting can include:

- playing with keys, phone, pen, etc.
- foot tapping
- nail biting
- Chewing bubble

Listen carefully

Communication does not just involve saying your piece.

In order to truly connect and share ideas with someone, you also have to listen — and listen well.

Barriers to Communication

A communication barrier is anything that prevents or distorts the intended meaning, message, information, ideas and thoughts at any stage of communication process.

They can interfere with or block the message you are trying to send.

They result in mismatch between understanding of the message by the sender and the receiver.

Communication barriers can be divided into:

- 1. Technical Barriers**
- 2. Language Barriers**
- 3. Psychological Barriers**
- 4. Semantic Barriers**
- 5. Emotional Barriers**
- 6. Barriers in Superiors**
- 7. Barriers in Subordinates**
- 8. Mechanical Barriers**
- 9. Physical Barriers**
- 10. Inter-Personal Barriers**
- 11. Cross-Cultural Barriers.**

Linguistic

The use of jargon, i.e. Over-complicated, unfamiliar and/or technical terms.

Some people may find it difficult to express their emotions and some topics may be completely 'off-limits' or taboo. Taboo or difficult topics may include, politics, religion, disabilities (mental and physical), private parts, racism and any opinion that may be seen as unpopular.

- **Lack of attention, interest, distractions, or irrelevance to the receiver.**
- **Differences in perception and viewpoint.**
- **Physical disabilities such as hearing problems or speech difficulties.**

- **Physical barriers to non-verbal communication.**

Not being able to see the non-verbal cues, gestures, posture and general body language can make communication less effective.

Phone calls, text messages and other communication methods that rely on technology are often less effective than face-to-face communication.

Cultural Differences

Culture is a shared set of values and attributes of a group. Culture differs in terms of language, values, norms of behaviour, concept of time and space, perception, basic personality, national character, etc.

Words, colours and symbols can have different meanings to different cultures.

Language differences and the difficulty in understanding unfamiliar accents.

False assumptions

Expectations and prejudices which may lead to false assumptions or stereotyping.

People often hear what they expect to hear rather than what is actually said and jump to incorrect conclusions.

Environmental

This refers to a range of factors such as size of room, layout of furniture, intrusive noise, heating and lighting etc. Each of these can either encourage or inhibit interaction.

Demographic

Factors such as gender and age can impact on the way in which a message is interpreted. For example, a male listener may nod his head to indicate to the speaker 'I agree', whereas a female listener may nod her head to communicate 'I am listening' (but not necessarily agreeing); so sending the same visible feedback but with different actual meanings (Stewart and Logan, 1998)

Disability

Physical or neurological impairment as well as psychiatric illness can call for alternative means to the usual patterns of communication to be adopted.

Some examples include sight or hearing loss, and conditions such as Parkinson's disease or severe depression (Hargie et al, 2004).

(Parkinson's disease is a brain disorder that leads to shaking, stiffness, and difficulty with walking, balance, and coordination.)

Organisational

Barriers to effective communication can be located within the organisation or agency itself.

Difficulties with established lines and means of communication, different relative physical location of staff, lack of team or supervision meetings, and under-resourced supervisors are factors that can impact negatively on effective communication.

Psychological

These include the perceptual biases or stereotypes that can impact on how we interpret a particular person's message.

Psychological barriers are 'Filtering, Assumptions, Fear, Inferiority, Emotions, Perception, and Poor Retention.

Thank You